

the hovering storm clouds of associated patents.

These patents have been around for a long time, the ever-increasing trend is using them in questionable ways against competition. As Jonathan Schwartz, President of Sun Microsystems put it, "Companies that acquire (often questionable) patents and later wield them against new market participants unleash a destructive force that stifles innovation and prevents participation-the polar opposite of the purpose for which patents were created."

TECHNOLOGY > RSS SYNDICATION

Tying The Web Together

RSS, Really Simple Syndication is making Really Big Waves. The concept is simple: the contents of a Web site are displayed to its audience in a timely and approachable manner. Powered by XML, RSS simply repackages a Web site as a list of data, such as the date of a post, a summary of the story and a link to it. RSS aggregators then take the package and display it on your computer. Every time the Web site is updated with new content, the aggregator can inform you of the same, saving you the trouble of revisiting it. An aggregator can take numerous avatars: it could be a plugin in your favourite e-mail client, it could be your e-mail client, could be your Web browser, an application sitting on your desktop, the form it takes is limited to the imagination of its creators.

Why is RSS such a big deal? Because it provides the backbone for two things: distribution of news and a means of instantaneous communication. Driven by both news-based Web sites and Web blogs, RSS is the only way to keep in touch with the diverse WWW.

EVENT > eBAY BUYS BAAZEE.COM

Baazee For \$50 million

The prehistoric e-commerce landscape of India showed signs of life, late 2004 when Mumbai-based Baazee was bought by eBay, the international, online bazaar where even parents are sold (never successfully though). The transaction happened for US \$50 million which amounts to some Rs 230 crore. Before you get envious of the dynamic duo behind Baazee (Avnish Bajaj and Suvir Sujan), most of that cash will be used to buy out shareholders News Corp, ICICI Ventures, Bid or Buy, Global Bridge Ventures, E-Vision Partners and some angel investors in the US.

This is interesting because eBay means business; it is always looking to aggressively push its online market forward. That it bought Baazee could either mean that they know something about the Indian online market that we don't or that they simply deemed it wise to purchase a company with presence, rather than start from scratch. Baazee haven't broken even yet, although they claim to have conducted transactions worth Rs 100 crore. Interestingly, Baazee revised its initial claim of 2.6 million registered members to a figure of 1 million confirmed registered users, after the sale.



I did, in fact, taste kangaroo meat at a luncheon... I enjoyed it
Jonathan Schwartz,
President of Sun
Microsystems

For the rest of us, this transaction translates to a wider audience to both buy and sell goods.

PEOPLE > JONATHAN SCHWARTZ

Putting The Fire In Sun

Jonathan Schwartz is the President and Chief Operating Officer at Sun Microsystems. That fact does not make him particularly special. During his tenure at Sun he has been responsible for the introduction of the Java System, and for the launch of Java Desktop System (which has gained good traction within the industry), his day-to-day activities involve operations and execution of Sun's business including Systems, Software, Global Sales Operations, worldwide manufacturing and purchasing, customer advocacy and worldwide marketing. So what? It is a job well paid for.

No, what makes Schwartz a personality in the IT sector, a voice heard, sometimes with derision, sometimes with respect, but always heard, is this little URL: <http://blogs.sun.com/jonathan>. Mr Schwartz, ladies and gents, is a blogger, and they don't make bloggers more passionate than him.

Schwartz is the word evangelist given flesh. He gets up on his Web podium and thumps the virtues of Sun's products to anyone and everyone who cares for a listen. His sometimes wry posts waste no time in bringing down his competitors—Red Hat or IBM—or in drumming up Sun's associations with allies such as Microsoft and SAP.

His blogs offer an insight into the workings of an US \$11 billion company. They sometimes inform, and sometimes amuse (they can be both genuinely funny and obviously a veiled press release), but they always make an interesting read.

On Intel's CEO, Barrett's insistence that gigahertz is dead: "Granted we had that viewpoint approximately three years ahead of Mr Barrett, but we're glad we're finally in agreement." On open sourcing Solaris 10, a CIO told him that the last thing he needed was more source code: "No offence intended, but you're not my target demographic. It's your developers, and they'd love the ability to see/evolve the source." On Open Source: "No matter what the cynics say, since its inception, Sun has been a believer in and contributor to Open Source communities-after all, we were built on an Open Source operating system. Open Source is in our blood, not just our press releases and billboards." On kangaroo meat: "I would like to inform everyone that reads my blog that I did, in fact, taste kangaroo meat at a luncheon yesterday... And I know this will likely disqualify me from public office at some point, but I need also confess, I enjoyed it. It even paired well with a good shiraz [sic]. There, I said it. Secret's out."

Schwartz grants Sun a human face and for that alone, he must be applauded; the tech world needs a personality such as him. blogs.sun.com/jonathan, a blog worth reading, for the man at the keyboard■

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